admit in private to the compulsion of not appearing "harsh" on Meiteis, who are largely Hindus. With the 2024 general election approaching, the saffron party doesn't want to be on the wrong side of a narrative that pits Hindu Meiteis against Christian Kukis. That's one reason experts believe the central government has allowed Biren and the state administration to set the narrative. On social media, the saffron support is clearly tilted towards valley folk.

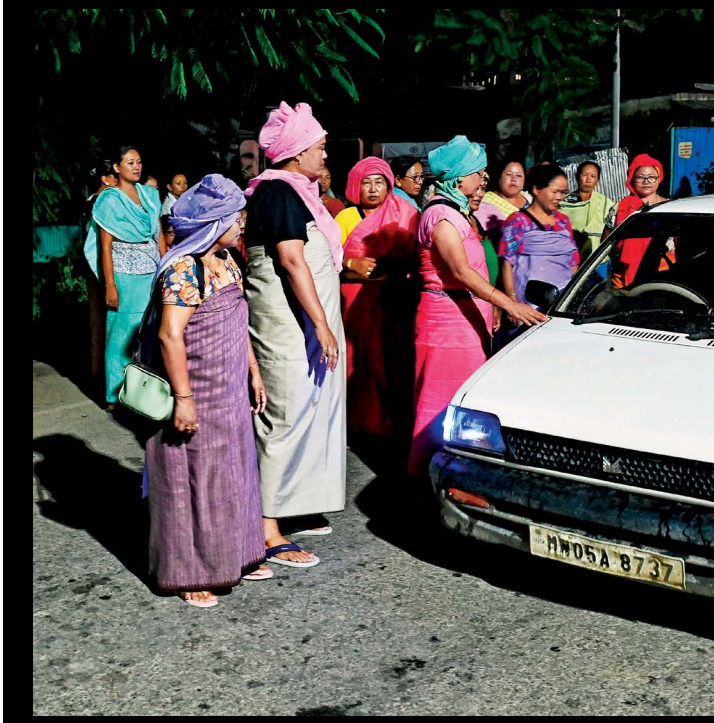
The schisms in the social fabric have only hardened with the emergence of hardline socio-political organisations that focus on Meitei identity and cultural revivalism, allegedly instigated by Hindutva supporters. Two such outfits, Arambai Tenggol and Meitei Leepun, have allegedly actively participated in the current violence. They also provide armed training to youth. While Arambai Tenggol was officially dissolved on May 26, Kuki groups claim their volunteers along with those of Meitei Leepun, and backed by the state administration and the police, are leading the raids in Kuki areas. Meitei Leepun's head Pramot Singh, however, claims it is a cultural organisation dedicated to protecting the Meitei way of life. "In our tradition, every person aged between 18 and 45 has to mandatorily serve as a soldier. Accordingly, we provide arms training to our youth," he says. What hasn't helped, though, is the fact that despite all the tall talk of curbing violence in the state, the Biren administration has issued 8,281 gun licences in the past six years, the highest in decades. As a result, there are an estimated 35,117 active gun licences in Manipur, the second-highest in the Northeast. It is a significant factor in the violence escalating to unprecedented levels.

WHAT CAN BE DONE

Having reached this disastrous pass, the dilemma in Manipur is how to come up with a solution that does not widen the abyss between the two communities triggering more violence. Right from the beginning of the clashes, there has been a demand for President's rule, particularly from the Opposition parties and the Kukis. However, several experts do not see it as the answer. The Shah-led home ministry is already directly monitoring the law-and-order situation in the state. Given that the state already had a 'double-engine' BJP government, President's rule will not change much, in this view. It will only formalise the rule of the Union government, with the state administration and police forces reporting directly to it. BJP insiders also feel the move may antagonise the Meiteis. Also, having seen separatist movements in the past, President's rule could aggravate such impulses, especially as several underground groups are activating their operations, seeking public support. And since the demand for President's rule is coming from the Kuki side, the Meiteis may see its imposition as an affront. "In the Imphal valley, non-cooperation of the state administration, which is now ethnically divided, will add to the chaos. The Kuki areas are already being run by the armed forces and the Union government. We stand to gain nothing except giving in to a fashionable demand," says a Union minister. Defence officers too admit that any action upsetting the Meiteis may trigger a bigger crisis. "Using lethal weapons is not an option," says a senior army official. "We try to negotiate peacefully to keep the situation under control. At worst, we can resort to non-lethal modes such as tear gas, but that's like buying temporary peace. The problem must be solved politically."

There has also been a growing demand for Biren's resignation or sacking for his inept handling of the crisis and indirect instigation in ethnically loaded statements. The Kukis see him as their prime enemy and replacing him, many feel, could open the door for negotiations with them. The BJP, however, is caught in a bind. By openly espousing his support for pet Meitei causes such as action against illegal immigrants—bound up with the war against poppy, both perceptibly targeted against Kukis—Biren has emerged as a hero of the community. This was evident in the massive crowd, of

MEITEI CHECK POST
Meitei women of the Moirang Apunba Meira Paibi Lup (MAMPIL) on vigil in Moirang



THE HOME MINISTRY HAS INITIATED TALKS WITH KUKI AND MEITEI LEADERS AND EXPECTS A BREAKTHROUGH SOON. PM MODI HIMSELF IS MONITORING EVERY DEVELOPMENT